

Aspirational Districts: Reservoirs of culture and untapped potential



Sanjeev Krishan
Chairperson
PwC in India



Jaivir Singh
Vice Chairman, PwC India Foundation and
Leader, Global Office for Humanitarian Affairs

Over the past decade, we have witnessed India's corporate social responsibility (CSR) ecosystem mature significantly. Leaders are increasingly conscious and working towards aligning their strategies with national development priorities. Right from education, healthcare, and nutrition to environmental sustainability and rural development, organisations are still focused on fuelling profit but with purpose at the heart of everything they aim to achieve. In FY23 alone, over INR34,908 crore was mobilised toward social impact initiatives. This surge has catalysed a vibrant ecosystem of implementing partners, including NGOs, social enterprises, and government bodies, with governance and impact measurement being prioritised. However, there is still a significant distance to cover.

Today, India stands out globally as one of the few countries to mandate CSR through legislation—turning corporate giving into a controlled, accountable component of business strategy rather than a tick-in-the-box exercise. Yet, beneath this lies a stark imbalance in how support is distributed. States like Maharashtra, Gujarat, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, and Delhi—home to major corporate hubs—continue to dominate CSR spending, receiving approximately 60–70% of the total funding. In contrast, low-income geographies such as the North-East and the 112 Aspirational Districts (ADs) identified by NITI Aayog remain severely underfunded, despite being among the most in need.

These districts, often located in border regions and ecologically fragile zones, represent some of the lowest-funded areas in the country. The 'local area preference' clause, while well-intentioned, inadvertently sidelines these geographies from meaningful investment, reinforcing a pattern of proximity-based giving that overlooks regions with the most pressing developmental needs. These underserved regions are coping with persistent challenges, and their exclusion from mainstream CSR narratives is not just a missed opportunity but also a developmental blind spot.

Given the uncertainty plaguing current times, coupled with frequent climate-associated emergencies, the need for equitable allocation of resources is more urgent than ever. These ADs are not just sites of vulnerability; they are also reservoirs of resilience, culture, and untapped potential.

While the government has made strides through initiatives such as the Border Area Development Programme (BAPD), the scale and complexity of challenges in these regions demand multi-sectoral collaboration. This is where the corporate sector must step in as a strategic partner—not only by way of capital assistance but also skills and time—to address critical needs, foster innovation, and build resilience in areas where state capacity may be stretched.

Encouragingly, some corporates have begun supporting education, healthcare, skill development, financial inclusion as well as biodiversity conservation in several regions, including border villages across states. Others are focused on sustainable agriculture and social forestry programmes, promoting climate-resilient farming and afforestation in tribal districts. Likewise, through the PwC India Foundation, our teams have been actively engaged in these districts, addressing developmental gaps and working to support the Government's vision of moving the needle on livelihoods and income generation. Through various initiatives in Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Punjab, Arunachal Pradesh, the Andaman Islands, and many others, we have been driving a focus on ecological preservation, sustainable agriculture, and livelihood enhancement, demonstrating that meaningful development work is both possible and necessary in complex terrains, although it requires a laser focus on outcomes that are measurable and lasting.

Looking ahead, India must move towards a future where CSR is not just a compliance exercise, but also a collaborative force aligned with the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and our national priorities. A consortium-based model that brings together businesses, NGOs, and government entities can foster resource-sharing, equality, and long-term resilience. The aim is to ultimately build inclusive growth models that reflect the diversity and complexity of India. It is time to move beyond metro-centric giving and towards a future where every region matters, and every community counts—leading to the collective growth of kal ka Bharat.

